STUDENT WELLNESS

Student Burnout Recovery Plan

Identifying burnout, rebuilding energy, and creating sustainable habits

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A Note from Dr. Hala

Dear student,

Burnout is not laziness. It is what happens when you have been running on empty for too long, when the demands on your time, energy, and emotional reserves exceed your ability to replenish them.

If you are reading this, you are probably already feeling it: the exhaustion that sleep does not fix, the cynicism about things you used to care about, the sense that no matter how hard you work, it is never enough.

This plan is designed to help you recognize burnout, understand what caused it, and take concrete steps toward recovery. You did not arrive here overnight, and you will not recover overnight either. But every small step matters.

With warmth, **Dr. Hala Ali** *Family & Youth Counselor*

Section 1: Recognizing Burnout

The Three Dimensions of Burnout

1. **Exhaustion:** Physical, emotional, and mental depletion. You feel tired even after resting.
2. **Cynicism:** Detachment and negativity toward your studies, activities, or relationships. Things that used to excite you now feel meaningless.
3. **Reduced efficacy:** The feeling that nothing you do makes a difference. Your confidence in your own abilities drops.

Burnout Self-Assessment

Rate each statement from 1 (never) to 5 (always):

- I feel physically exhausted most days _____
- I dread going to class or doing schoolwork _____
- I have trouble concentrating even on things I enjoy _____
- I feel emotionally numb or disconnected _____
- I have withdrawn from friends or activities _____

- I get sick more often than usual _____
- I feel like my efforts do not matter _____
- I have trouble sleeping or sleep too much _____
- I feel irritable or short-tempered _____
- I cannot remember the last time I felt truly rested _____

Scoring: 10-20: Mild stress. 21-35: Warning signs. 36-50: Burnout territory, please seek support.

Section 2: Understanding Your Burnout

Common Causes for Students

- Academic overload without adequate breaks
- Perfectionism and fear of failure
- Lack of social support or meaningful connection
- Financial stress or working while studying
- Family expectations and cultural pressure
- Comparison with high-achieving peers
- Loss of autonomy, feeling like your life is not your own

The Burnout Equation

Burnout = High Demands + Low Resources + Low Recovery

To recover, you need to address all three parts: reduce demands where possible, increase your resources and support, and prioritize recovery.

Section 3: The Recovery Plan

Week 1-2: Emergency Measures

These are immediate actions to stop the bleeding:

1. **Cancel one thing.** Look at your schedule and remove the lowest-priority commitment. Give yourself permission.
2. **Set a hard stop time each night.** No studying after this hour. Non-negotiable.

3. **Sleep.** This is not optional. Aim for 7-8 hours. Burnout recovery starts with rest.
4. **Move your body gently.** A 15-minute walk. Stretching. Yoga. Nothing intense.
5. **Reach out to one person.** Tell someone you trust how you are feeling.

Week 3-4: Rebuilding

1. **Audit your commitments.** What can you drop, delegate, or postpone?
2. **Reintroduce one enjoyable activity.** Something that is not productive, just pleasurable.
3. **Create a sustainable study schedule.** One that includes breaks, buffer time, and days off.
4. **Practice saying no.** Start small. Build the muscle.
5. **Eat regular meals.** Burnout recovery requires fuel.

Month 2+: Sustainable Habits

1. **Build recovery into your routine,** not as an afterthought but as a priority
2. **Set boundaries around your time and energy**
3. **Regularly check in with yourself:** "How am I doing, really?"
4. **Maintain your support network**
5. **Watch for relapse signs** and intervene early

Section 4: Preventing Future Burnout

The Sustainable Success Model

Success is not about grinding until you break. It is about finding a pace you can maintain over the long term. Ask yourself:

- "Can I maintain this pace for the next six months?"
- "Am I sacrificing my health for my grades?"
- "What would I tell a friend who was this exhausted?"

Your Non-Negotiables

Write down three things that are non-negotiable for your wellbeing:

1. _____
2. _____

3

These are the things you protect even when everything else gets busy.

Ready for Personalized Support?

Your first conversation is free — 30 minutes, no pressure. Let's explore how counseling can help you and your family thrive.

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